2.3 Slavery and Resistance

When one group of people oppresses another, the oppressed group eventually revolts. During the 19th century, enslaved communities and individuals alike rose up.

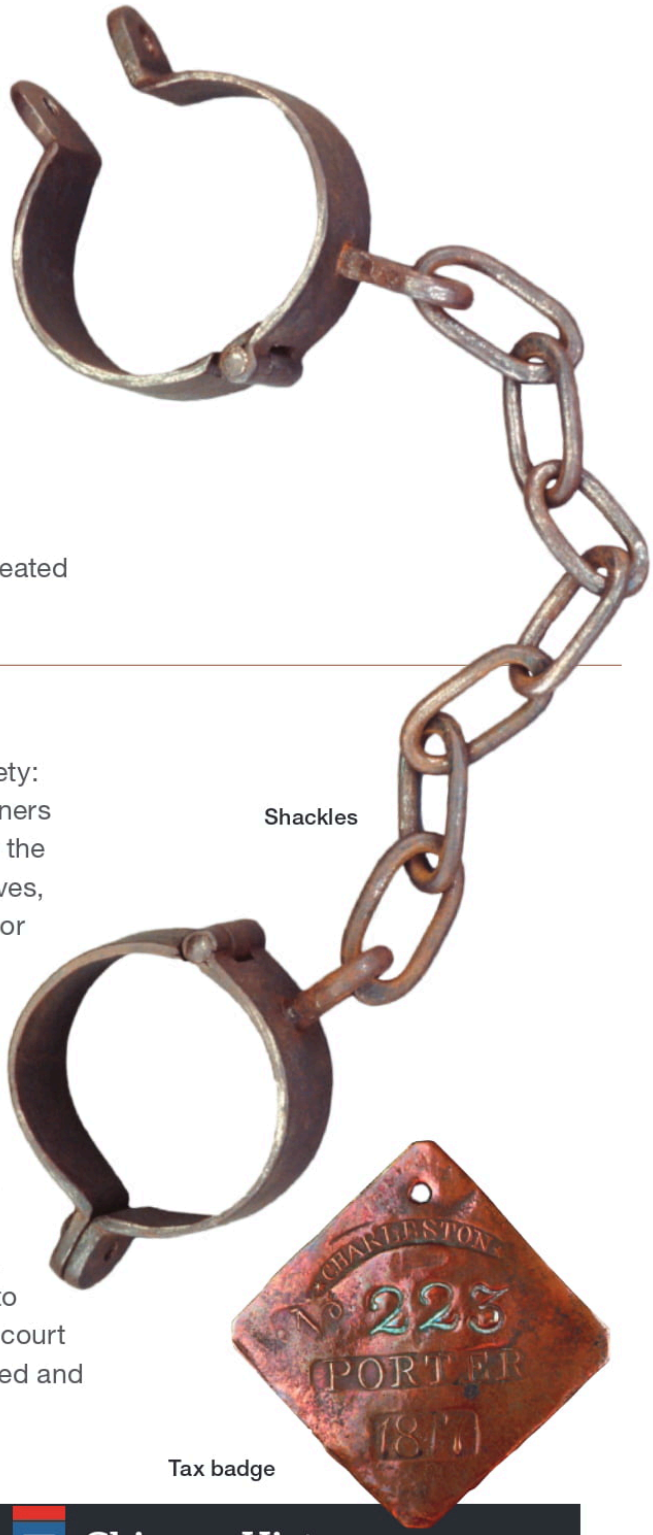
MAIN IDEA People trapped in the institution of slavery created a culture of survival, resistance, and, ultimately, rebellion.

THE SOCIETAL IMPACT OF SLAVERY

The institution of slavery affected all parts of southern society: wealthy or poor, slave or free, white or black. Plantation owners greatly advanced their wealth through slavery. Even though the majority of southern white farmers workers did not own slaves, they supported the practice of slavery. In the **antebellum**, or prewar, South, the poorest whites held higher status than any African Americans.

During the early 19th century, more than 100,000 free African Americans lived in the South, and they most certainly did not support slavery. Though they were free, they could not vote, own property, or receive an education. Legally, their status was constantly in question. Traveling was dangerous because they ran the risk of being accused of being runaway slaves and losing their freedom. In order to prove their free status, free African Americans had to go to court for Certificates of Freedom. Even then, some were kidnapped and sold into slavery.

The greatest impact of slavery, of course, was on enslaved people themselves. Slaves were considered chattel, or property, of their owners and were denied rights, freedom, and sometimes even their lives. Slave owners held a particularly ominous form of power over slaves with the constant possibility of family separation. Just the threat of sale allowed slave owners to exercise enormous control over their slaves. Enslaved parents routinely saw their children sold away from them. Spouses and siblings were separated, and they knew that future contact would be nearly impossible.



Shackles

Tax badge

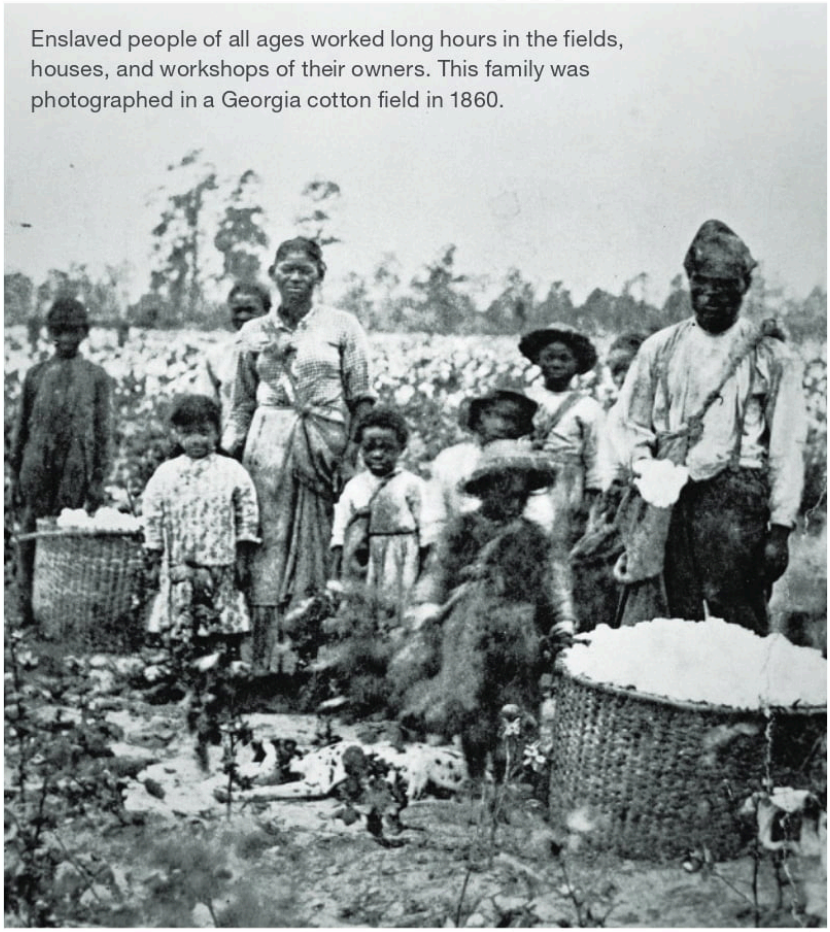
Chicago History Museum, Chicago

The system of slavery relied on preventing escapes. Slave owners placed shackles like these on enslaved people's wrists or ankles. The cuffs were held closed by a screw. In Charleston, South Carolina, enslaved workers who were hired out by their owners had to wear tax badges engraved with tax registration numbers and job categories.

Copyright 2025 Cengage Learning. All Rights Reserved. May not be copied, scanned, or duplicated, in whole or in part. Due to electronic rights, some third party content may be suppressed from the eBook and/or eChapter(s). Editorial review has deemed that any suppressed content does not materially affect the overall learning experience. Cengage Learning reserves the right to remove additional content at any time if subsequent rights restrictions require it.

SURVIVAL AND RESISTANCE

Despite the horrific conditions under which they lived, enslaved people resisted the circumstances they faced every day. Many slave owners imposed their own religious beliefs on slaves because they suggested that a belief in Christianity would make slavery an acceptable situation. But enslaved people interpreted scripture for themselves, in ways that encouraged a quest for freedom. They also composed songs called **spirituals** based on scripture and biblical figures such as Moses, who led the Israelites out of slavery in Egypt.



Enslaved people of all ages worked long hours in the fields, houses, and workshops of their owners. This family was photographed in a Georgia cotton field in 1860.

In addition to their own religious practices, enslaved people developed a distinct African-American culture. They retained and adapted traditional customs including music, food, and dancing, as well as varied family structures. They created rich communities bound together by common experiences and shared traditions. In this way, enslaved people asserted their humanity, which could not be taken away by slave owners.

Passive resistance, or the nonviolent refusal to obey authority and laws, was another way enslaved people resisted slavery. Forms of passive resistance included breaking tools, working slowly, pretending to be ill, and learning to read.

Sometimes, though, resistance meant armed rebellion. Inspired by a slave uprising in Haiti, in 1800, a slave named **Gabriel Prosser**, who bore the last name of his cruel owner, Thomas Prosser, planned a revolt in Virginia. In 1822, a freed slave named **Denmark Vesey** used scripture to inspire others to take over arsenals and burn down buildings in Charleston, South Carolina. Most revolts, including these, were put down quickly before whites were killed, and they resulted in the deaths of the enslaved people who had planned the rebellions.

But in 1831, **Nat Turner** led a small group of fellow slaves in a violent rebellion in which more than 50 people were killed in one night. Turner and his men were captured and hanged. Southerners reacted to Turner's rebellion—as they had to others—with violence. Some took matters into their own hands and murdered hundreds of innocent slaves.

Like Gabriel Prosser and Denmark Vesey, Turner was a literate man who led an open, violent revolt against slave-owning whites. Southern authorities reacted to Turner's revolt forcefully and by instituting severe restrictions, including a ban on teaching slaves to read and write.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** In what ways did enslaved people resist slavery?
2. **DRAW CONCLUSIONS** Why did free African Americans need Certificates of Freedom?
3. **MAKE CONNECTIONS** Why was literacy for slaves a threat to slave owners?

Copyright 2025 Cengage Learning. All Rights Reserved. May not be copied, scanned, or duplicated, in whole or in part. Due to electronic rights, some third party content may be suppressed from the eBook and/or eChapter(s). Editorial review has deemed that any suppressed content does not materially affect the overall learning experience. Cengage Learning reserves the right to remove additional content at any time if subsequent rights restrictions require it.